YORK REGION FOOD CHARTER

YORK REGION FOOD COUNCIL

The York Region Food Charter outlines collective values and priorities and is a guiding document for food-related policies and action.

The Food Charter is a vision of thriving urban and rural communities as well as First Nations and Indigenous Communities where residents, organizations, businesses, and governments work together to create a resilient food system that fosters healthy communities.

The Food Charter is centered on food sovereignty[1] and community-determined food and agriculture systems. This document is intended to build connection and responsibility to the land, and healthier food systems.



01. Equity, Social Justice & Food Security[2]

We value the right to food and community-determined food and agriculture systems. We believe everyone should have enough income to effectively prevent food insecurity. [3]



02. Health & Well-Being

We value the role of food in promoting health, including physical, mental, emotional, cultural, social and spiritual well-being.



03. Local Agri-Food Sector[4]

We value the role of the agri-food sector in cultivating a strong economy and equitable local food system while ensuring environmental sustainability.



04. Environmental Stewardship

We value a sustainable food system that protects and enhances the natural environment while working alongside First Nations and Indigenous Communities.



05. Knowledge & Sharing

We value sharing knowledge and supporting food literacy[5] so that all community members can confidently choose to grow, cook, compost, or participate in food-related careers, contributing to a more sustainable future for the next seven generations.



06. Community & Culture

We value food as a link that brings communities together and connects people to people, land, culture and identity.

We seek to meaningfully engage diverse voices that represent York Region's communities and address issues in appropriate and relevant ways. By addressing food related issues, we strive to have a local impact while working towards systemic change in food, community and social justice. This includes reconciliation and supporting the resurgence of knowledge and traditional ways of knowing and doing.

The York Region food system is built on a history of oppression that continues to this day. The impact of this oppression is vast and includes a disconnection from the land and the loss of natural ways of living on the land, such as freely foraging and harvesting food. The ongoing process of colonialism has attempted to undermine the traditional and cultural food traditions of Indigenous, Black and racialized communities. We recognize that these communities continue to be impacted disproportionately by food insecurity, which can only be addressed by self-governance and support, if requested.

1. *"The right of peoples to healthy and culturally appropriate food produced through ecologically sound and sustainable methods, and their right to define their own food and agriculture systems" (La Via Campesina).*
2. *Food security is "when all people, at all times, have physical and economic access to sufficient sage and nutritious food that meets their dietary needs and food preferences for an active and healthy life." (Food and Agriculture Organization, World Food Summit, 1996)*
3. *"Food insecurity is the inadequate or insecure access to food due to financial constraints" (PROOF, 2024).*
4. *The agri-food sector is the actors and activities involved in the production of agricultural products, as well as in storage, post-harvest handling, value-added activities, transportation, processing, distribution, marketing, disposal and consumption of all food and agricultural products (FAO, 2021).*
5. *Food literacy the ability to make informed decisions about the impact of your food choices on health, community, economy and environment. It is also the understanding that the impacts of food choices are not experienced equitably (Food Literacy Centre, 2019).*

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